CODE HILLS 1001 — Business Plan

Fresha Route — Umwenya (Lemongrass)

> Part of the CODE HILLS 1001 business-plan library (6 plans total, built from Rwanda's natural resources: Umuravumba, Tea, Coffee, Umwenya, Sisal). Figures in RWF are labeled estimates — verify current local prices, supply arrangements, and regulatory requirements (RDB/RFDA/technical institute) before investing.

LOW-CAPITAL BUSINESS 2 — "Fresha Route" (Umwenya / Lemongrass)

1. Business Identity

- **Name:** Fresha Route
- **Tagline:** *"Clean seats, clean stalls, fresh air — on every route."*
- **Resource:** Umwenya (lemongrass).
- **Concept:** A refill-bottle subscription service delivering a natural lemongrass-based surface-cleaning and deodorizing concentrate to moto-taxi associations, shared minibus operators, and market-stall vendors, replacing single-use synthetic sprays and ad-hoc cleaning habits.
- **What makes it unique:** It is not lemongrass tea or lemongrass oil sold as a retail bottle. It is a **B2B hygiene-as-a-service route business** with a reusable-bottle deposit system, built around Rwanda's dense shared-transport and market economy rather than a beverage or wellness shelf.

2. Problem

Shared motos, minibuses (twegerane/matatu-style vans), and market stalls in Rwanda are used by many different people daily, and odor/hygiene upkeep is inconsistent and typically relies on either nothing, water only, or imported synthetic sprays that are relatively costly for small operators. Moto and minibus associations, and market vendor cooperatives, have an ongoing (not one-time) need for an affordable, pleasant-smelling, locally made surface freshener/light cleaner.

3. Solution

Fresha Route grows/sources lemongrass, distills or infuses a concentrated cleaning-and-freshening liquid, and delivers it on a **fixed weekly/bi-weekly route** to signed-up moto stages, minibus stations, and market-stall clusters, refilling reusable spray bottles rather than selling disposable ones — turning a one-time product idea into a **recurring local delivery service**.

4. Product

- **Fresha Concentrate (500ml refill pouch):** Diluted 1:4 with water by the customer into a reusable spray bottle provided at signup.
- **Stall Wipe-Down Liquid (1L, for market vendors):** A slightly stronger dilution for wiping down stall surfaces/coolers.
- **Variations:** A citronella-boosted version marketed for outdoor stalls (mosquito-comfort angle, secondary benefit, no medical claim).
- **Format:** Reusable pump-spray bottles (deposit-based, returned/refilled on each visit) + refill pouches only — no new bottle sold on repeat visits.
- **Why customers want it:** Cheaper per-use than buying new synthetic spray bottles repeatedly; pleasant, recognizably local scent customers can build a stage/stall reputation around ("we use Fresha here").
- **Hard to confuse with a generic product** because the entire commercial relationship is a **recurring refill route to transport/market associations**, not a bottled retail good on a shelf.

5. Sustainability

- **Sourcing:** Lemongrass is fast-growing and can be intercropped on small plots or field edges; harvesting (cutting blades) does not kill the plant, which regrows from the base.
- **Waste minimization:** Spent plant fiber after infusion/distillation is dried and sold or given as mulch/animal bedding.
- **Packaging:** Reusable spray bottles collected and refilled on-route; refill pouches designed to be the *only* disposable component, minimized in size and, over time, made from a compostable or sisal-fiber-reinforced pouch **[future development — verify local pouch-supplier options before committing]**.
- **Energy/water:** Cold-infusion methods avoid the fuel needed for steam distillation where volumes are small; water use is limited to the infusion step.
- **End-of-life:** Spent liquid/plant matter is biodegradable; bottles are designed for a multi-year reuse life rather than single use.
- **Path to zero/near-zero waste:** As volume grows, the business can shift from pouch refills to **bulk drum refills at fixed community stations** (customers bring their own bottle to a stage-based refill point), eliminating packaging waste almost entirely.

6. Target Customers

- Moto-taxi stage associations (B2B contracts).
- Minibus/shared-van station operators.

- Market vendor cooperatives (stall cleaning).
- Small shops/salons wanting a pleasant, local-scent hygiene product (secondary B2C channel).

7. Competitive Advantage

- **Advantage source:** A recurring-revenue route model plus a distribution relationship (transport/market associations) that is unusual for a "lemongrass product" idea, combined with the deposit-bottle system that lowers customers' switching cost away from Fresha Route once bottles are out in the field.
- **Why competitors may not immediately copy this:** Building a delivery route and trust with moto/minibus association leaders takes real relationship-building and a working refill logistics system — not something a one-off "sell lemongrass spray" idea replicates quickly.

8. Startup Requirements

Essential: - Lemongrass source (own small plot, or purchase bundles from local farmers). - Basic infusion equipment (large pots, cheesecloth/strainers) — no distillation still required at small scale. - Reusable spray bottles (initial batch, seen as an asset the business owns and circulates). - Bicycle or on-foot route capacity for the first stage cluster. - Simple ledger for tracking which stage/stall has which bottle. **Add later:** - A motorcycle for wider routes. - A small steam distillation unit if scaling into a stronger concentrate line. - Printed route-branding stickers for bottles.

9. Startup Budget (RWF, estimates)

Item	Minimum	Recommended
Lemongrass (first batches)	10,000	30,000
Infusion pots/strainers	15,000	35,000
30 reusable spray bottles	60,000	90,000
Refill pouches (first run)	20,000	40,000
Bicycle for route (if not owned)	0 (own bike)	80,000
Registration/branding	10,000	25,000
Total	**≈115,000–125,000**	**≈300,000**

10. Unit Economics

- **Refill pouch (500ml):** Cost ≈ 900 RWF → Sold/billed at 2,000 RWF per refill visit → Gross profit ≈ 1,100 RWF (~55% margin).
- At **10 refills/day**: ≈11,000 RWF/day gross profit.
- At **30 refills/day** (multiple stages on a route day): ≈33,000 RWF/day gross profit.
- At **100 refills/day** (multi-route, likely requires 1–2 hired route staff): ≈110,000 RWF/day gross profit before route staff wages, which become a real cost at this scale.

11. Production Process

1. Harvest lemongrass blades; wash.
2. Chop and steep in hot water (cold-infusion alternative for energy saving) for several hours with a light natural surfactant (verify a food/skin-safe option locally, e.g., a small amount of castile-type soap base, before finalizing formulation).
3. Strain; store concentrate in food-grade containers.
4. Dilute per product line at point of refill.
5. Track each bottle's refill date/route for quality and hygiene control. **Quality/safety notes:** Since this is a cleaning product touching public surfaces, keep concentration and any surfactant sourcing consistent and clearly labeled; avoid claiming disinfectant/antimicrobial efficacy unless tested and certified — market it honestly as a **natural cleaning and freshening liquid**.

12. Marketing Strategy (first 30 days)

- **Week 1:** Approach the leadership of 1–2 moto stages and 1 market vendor group directly with a free trial week.
- **Week 2:** Film a short WhatsApp-shareable video of the refill process at a stage; ask the association leader to share it in their own group.
- **Week 3:** Offer a "first bottle free, pay from second refill" trial to reduce adoption friction.
- **Week 4:** Expand to a second stage/market cluster using the first as a reference.

13. Sales Strategy

- **Where:** Direct B2B visits to stage/market leadership; word-of-mouth within associations.
- **Pricing:** Per-refill billing, paid via mobile money at time of route visit.
- **First 10 customers:** Individual moto riders or stall owners within the first pilot stage/market.
- **Feedback:** Ask at every refill visit — this is a route model, so feedback collection is built into the operating rhythm.
- **Model:** Recurring refill subscription (weekly/bi-weekly), not one-time sales — this is the core of the business.

14. Growth Plan

1. **Home/small production** — one route, one person.
2. **Small workshop** — dedicated infusion space, 2–3 routes.
3. **Local brand** — recognized “Fresha Route” branding on bottles across a district.
4. **Rwanda-wide distribution** — franchised or licensed routes operated by trained local partners in other towns.
5. **Regional opportunity** — the model (not necessarily the product) could be licensed into similar dense-transport markets in the region — **[ASSUMPTION, long-term, unverified]**.

15. Risks

Risk	Mitigation
Bottle loss/non-return	Deposit system; simple bottle-tracking ledger
Inconsistent lemongrass supply	Multiple small suppliers; own backup plot
Route time inefficiency	Cluster customers geographically before expanding
Perception as “just a spray” undervaluing the service	Emphasize the *route relationship and reliability*, not the liquid alone, in all messaging
Seasonal transport demand shifts	Diversify into market-stall and small-shop customers, not transport alone
Cash flow from small per-visit payments	Mobile-money collection at time of service; simple daily reconciliation

16. 90-Day Launch Plan

- **Weeks 1–2:** Confirm lemongrass source; test infusion formula.
- **Weeks 3–4:** Pilot with one stage (free week); collect feedback.
- **Weeks 5–6:** Introduce paid refills; refine bottle/route logistics.
- **Weeks 7–8:** Add second customer cluster (market stalls).
- **Weeks 9–10:** Register business; formalize simple B2B agreement wording with association leaders.
- **Weeks 11–12:** Review unit economics from real data; reinvest in more bottles/route capacity.

Originality Test

1. **Obvious idea:** Lemongrass tea, lemongrass essential oil, or a bottled “natural spray” sold in shops.
2. **Structural difference:** Recurring B2B refill-route service to transport/market associations, not a retail bottled product.
3. **Distinctive combination:** Resource (lemongrass) + problem (shared-space hygiene/odor) + customer (moto/minibus/market associations) + business model (deposit-bottle refill subscription) + distribution (fixed delivery route).
4. **Hard to copy because:** Requires an actual working relationship and logistics route with association leaders and a bottle-tracking system — not just a product formulation.